Operations of the AI1348 flight, after returning from the successful evacuation operation recalled that the deathly silence in the aircraft that was devoid of any radio chatter and the eerie quietness of a locked-down Wuhan felt apocalyptic while descending. A second flight brought back 323 Indians on 2 February that year.[36]

The returning passengers were then sent to the two quarantine centres set up by the Indian Armed Forces at Manesar and Chawla Camp near New Delhi. From the returnees, those with any symptoms or comorbidities were sent to Safdarjung Hospital for monitoring.[37] A 30-something-year-old specialist, Dr Nitish Gupta was on the frontline monitoring and preparing the hospital to treat in case of COVID-19-positive cases. He and his team were studying infection-control practices emerging from China and Italy and putting in place standard operating procedures (SOPs) for the hospital which would include use of PPE kits, N95 masks for all healthcare and frontline staff attending to the patients, negative suction doors, isolated rooms for those testing positive and so on. None of the Wuhan returnees tested positive for the virus but Dr Gupta would later say, ‘The whole team at the hospital was on its toes. In the absence of clarity on how the virus spreads and how it can be treated, not only were the patients afraid, but even the hospital team was extremely fearful.’

From the Indians in Hubei who wanted to return to their country, there were several Indians who weren’t allowed to board the flights on account of their body temperatures being higher than what the Chinese government had allowed as part its travel protocol. On 8 February, Prime Minister Modi wrote to Chinese president Xi, conveying the solidarity of the people and the Government of India (GoI) with the people of China and the readiness of the Indian government to provide assistance.[38] Following that letter, India sent about 15 tonnes worth of medical equipment comprising surgical masks, surgical gloves, infusion pumps, enteral feeding pumps, defibrillators and N95 masks.[39] These supplies were delivered by an Indian Air Force C-17 special flight, which after delivering the equipment to the Hubei Charity Federation, ferried back the remaining Indians who wanted to return but were not allowed to board the two previous flights due to high body temperature.

Eventually, India ended up evacuating not only its own citizens but also helped about 80 other countries bring back theirs. India solidified its footing as a ‘first and fast’ responder during the crisis, be it during Wuhan or the